



ThinkCollege

INSTITUTE FOR COMMUNITY INCLUSION, UMASS BOSTON

The Think College Inclusive Higher Education Network: Building Awareness and Capacity for Higher Education and Employment for People with Intellectual Disability

OUR MISSION.

The Think College Inclusive Higher Education Network was funded in 2021 as a National Technical Assistance and Dissemination Center by the Office of Postsecondary Education, US Department of Education. The mission of this center is to build awareness and capacity for increased access to higher education and employment for students with intellectual disability. This center is designed to support inclusive higher education programs across the country, extending the knowledge learned from the Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability (TPSID) model demonstration projects and applying it more widely.



The Inclusive Higher Education Network works with strategic partners to broaden our capacity to achieve project goals. Partners include the Association of University Centers on Disability, Florida Center for Students with Unique Abilities, Midwest Inclusive Postsecondary Education Alliance, Southeast Postsecondary Education Alliance, Virginia Commonwealth University's Rehabilitation Research and Training Center, and Westchester Institute for Human Development.

BUILDING AWARENESS.

We are creating and implementing a robust public awareness campaign that shares the impact and importance of higher education for students with intellectual disability. The campaign—**Think Higher, Think College**—will encourage students, families, educators, and higher education professionals to learn more about the promising outcomes of inclusive higher education.

TRANSLATING RESEARCH INTO PRACTICE.

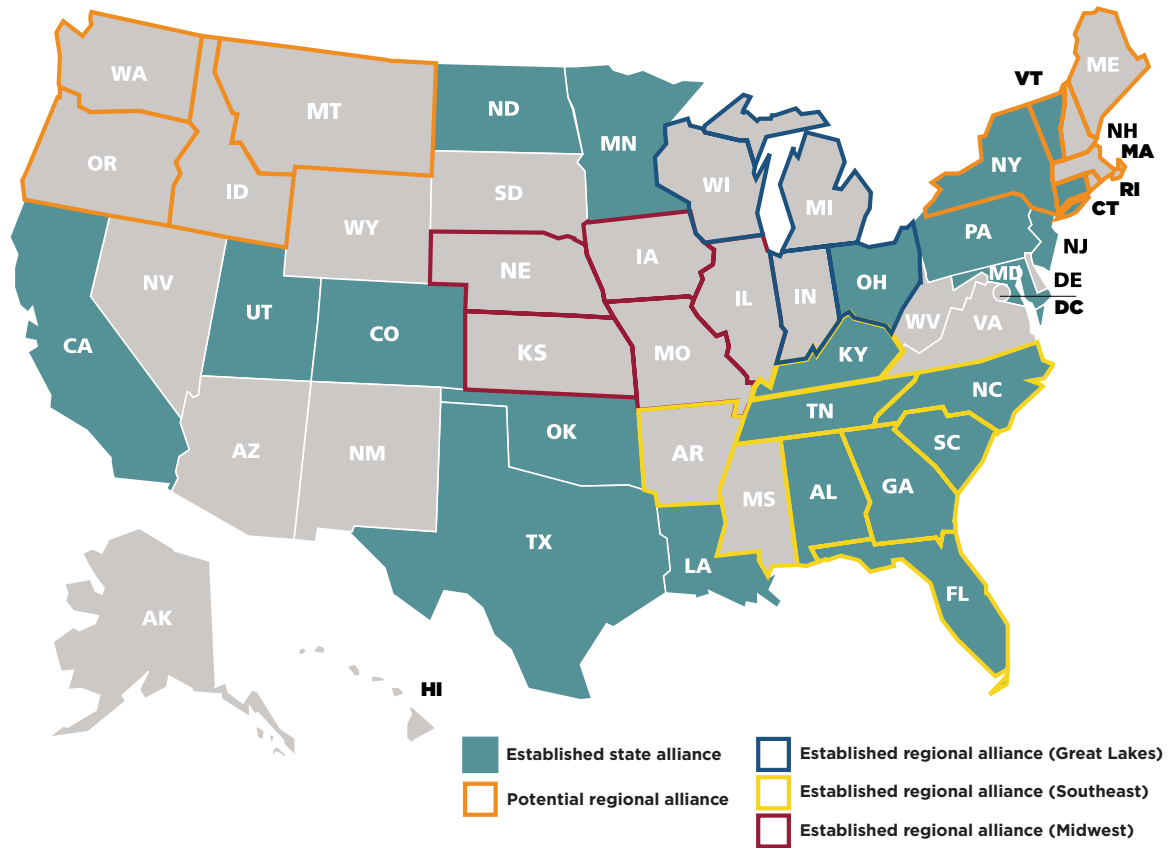
The center supports faculty, program staff, and others to improve the quality and outcomes of inclusive higher education programs by reviewing and synthesizing research findings, and translating them into accessible tools, resources, and strategies.

CREATING STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIPS.

The center has created two workgroups which focus on addressing systemic gaps in the areas of employment partnerships and career and technical education (CTE). These groups foster collaboration amongst invested professionals who work to identify and address barriers in policy and practice in order to build stronger pathways to employment. The workgroups provide a bridge for connecting Vocational Rehabilitation and Developmental Disabilities agencies and the expansion of options for students with intellectual disability within CTE, to strengthen college access and improved outcomes for students with intellectual disability.

INCREASING REGIONAL CAPACITY.

We are building a network of state and regional alliances, creating locally responsive partnerships to better support higher education programs for students with intellectual disability. By offering guidance and training to alliances as emerging leaders in the field, we increase their capacity to work together to address systems change issues and build stronger, more sustainable inclusive higher education options.



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